

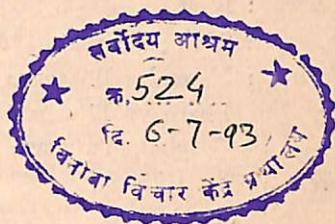
ANECDOTES OF VINOBA

A. V. BARVE

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SARVA SEVA SANGH PRAKASHAN

ANECDOTES OF VINOBA



by

V-1-19

A. V. Barve

Preface by

N. V. Gadgil

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PUBLISHER'S NOTE

Shri Anant Vinayak Barve has thought deeply over Vinoba's Bhoodan-Gramdan campaign and has come to the conclusion that it has touched the hearts of the rich and the poor alike with profuse feeling and love. It is his conviction that Bhoodan-Gramdan campaign is the way to bring about an equalitarian society based on compassion by eradicating the disparity between the haves and have-nots. By including about fifty reminiscences in this small book, Shri Barve has, in fact, laid bare the very core of the campaign.

Unfortunately, Shri Anant Barve, the writer of this book, breathed his last on Sept. 30, 1965. The writer of the preface, Shri Kaka Saheb Gadgil, too is now no more with us.

Had we been able to publish the book during their life time it would have been a matter of immense pleasure for us. We express our gratitude to the departed souls for their labour and contribution to this noble cause.

CONTENTS

1. The soul is immortal.	..	1
2. How came the inspiration ?	..	2
3. God in every thing.	..	4
4. The miracle of Mangroth.	..	5
5. The story of Manpur.	..	8
6. The Boy donor.	..	11
7. The origin of 'Gitai'.	..	12
8. Vinoba in the land of Buddha.	..	14
9. Be truly royal in spirit.	..	15
10. A true Harijan or servant of God.	..	16
11. The solitary Chamar donor of Badagaon.	..	18
12. The shining example of Tikardi.	..	20
Kanpur ranks first.	..	21
14. The two brothers quarrel.	..	24
15. Let children not be idlers.	..	25
16. Sakshi Gopal or God is my witness.	..	26
7. The tragic incident of Vaidyanath Dhama.	..	28
18. Lanza Del Vasta or Shantidas Bhai	..	29
19. A noble kind of competition.	..	31
20. Mohammad Pathan of Gumgaon.	..	32
21. The Modern Monkey Army.	..	34
22. Lord Krishna, Murali and Gokul.	..	35
23. A representative of rural India.	..	37
24. Who came to scoff.	..	38
25. A clairvoyant blind man.	..	40
26. All out for Jayaprakashji.	..	42

PREFACE

'Anecdotes of Vinoba' is a collection of remarkable incidents in the life of Shri Vinoba during the last twenty-five years. Mr. Barve, the author, has made an excellent selection and every piece has a moral of its own, and an individuality which distinguishes it from the rest of the pieces. Hence this collection is unique in my view.

Shri Vinobaji is a great scholar of Vedic literature and a great philosopher, and yet he is a man of action and that makes him a unique and a great personality in the contemporary history of India. Right from ancient times there has been a continuous struggle between the rich and the poor, the lucky and the unlucky, the haves and the have-nots and during these hundreds of years, great Saints have made attempts in their own way to bridge over the gap and make the life of the poor and the neglected a bit happier and more tolerable. But, nobody has touched the fundamental character of the society which is deeply possessional. Confucius, Lord Buddha and Jesus Christ, all in their own way, preached the doctrine of non-possession and sacrifice. The appeal has always been in terms of religion. From the eighteenth century onward the very conception of property came to be analysed and eventually, this enquiry led to the foundation of the doctrine that all property belongs to the community and as such is inheritable and enjoyable by every member of the community. This version really corresponds to the Upanishad doctrine, "ईशावास्यं इदं सर्वं". 'All this belongs to God' and, if you want to enjoy it, you

have to give it up'. “तेन त्यक्तेन मुंजीथा”. Somehow or other this Vedic conception of property did not become a working principle in the life of the common man. If there were examples of parting with property in favour of the weak and the poor, the motive therein was—not duty so much and certainly not the appreciation that the property belonged to the community—but an impulse steeped in charity. The act showed that the donor had fine feelings, but these exceptions remained merely exceptions and the modern society continued to be more and more acquisitive.

In the Nineteenth Century, Marx preached his doctrines and gave a new context and a new meaning to the idea of private property. It was, so to say, putting a time-bomb underneath the berth of complacency and *status quo* of the Western society prevalent then. It did explode half a century later and from 1917 onward—that means after the Russian Revolution attempts were made to translate the teachings of Marx into current values in the economic and political life in Russia to begin with. India needed no such doctrine; for, this country centuries before had a clear conception of property. The fact that property can only be created in a society and that even private property is the result of a partnership between the individual and the society, came to be realized. Whatever one considers to be private property, he does so because the society recognizes it. It is not by any unilateral declaration that what I hold becomes my property, but it is so because the society recognizes that to be my property and the State guarantees peaceful enjoyment of the same to me. What Gandhiji, and later on Vinoba, did in this sphere amounted to making the possessor feel that the right to hold property carried an obligation to share

it with those who are weaker and less fortunate. “सबै भूमि गोपाल की” means communal ownership of the property.

Gandhiji reiterated the Vedic conception of land belonging to God, in other words, to the entire community. It was Shri Vinoba's contribution to give a concrete form to this doctrine and the result was his Bhoodan movement. Mr. Barve's collection gives some idea as to how the conception occurred, how it became popular and how it spread throughout the country during a short period of twelve years. Bhoodan is not merely something of economic significance. In my view, it has a spiritual background, an ethical approach and economic consequences. The doctrine of equality and the dignity of personal labour are well expressed and are implicit also in the conception of Bhoodan. The ultimate aim of Bhoodan was obvious and it became clear when villages were donated. Now, for Bhoodan movement to become a permanent feature of the political and economic landscape of this country, it is necessary that certain procedures have to be worked out. Some such experiments have been done in Orissa, but the measure of success that is recorded is not entirely satisfactory. Whatever it is, Vinobaji's philosophy has affected both political and economic thinking of the country. His influence has also affected some of the Western thinkers and in view of this, this collection of various incidents connected with Vinoba's life, is a welcome effect. I have no doubt that the English reading public will find it interesting.

—N. V. Gadgil.

FIVE MINUTES WITH VINOBA

The sweet 'salunki'

Her clear note outpoureth.

God gives as she soareth,

All the rapture.

—*St. Tukaram.*

On the eve of the publication of *Anecdotes of Vinoba* it would but be in the fitness of things, if I take my readers' precious five minutes, to cast a glance at the life of this wonderful God-man of action—a miracle of earnest endeavour and finest achievement.

Like the great Lokamanya Tilak before him, Vinoba made up his mind, in his early 'teens', to serve his motherland with all his might. He thought of searching for and finding a Guru who could lovingly guide him in his sacred resolution to serve mother India.

Vinoba found his spiritual and political father in Mahatma Gandhi—the Father of Modern Bharat. Mahatma Gandhi's famous Benares speech had many consequences, one of them being the creation of the relation of father and son between the Mahatma and Vinoba Bhave. To put it shortly, he quickly grasped the technique of love and non-violence and achieved the distinction of being one of the Mahatma's great followers, another being Jawaharlal Nehru. These two were the Castor and Pollux lighting the Indian social and political firmament. Alas ! Nehru is no longer with us. Vinoba liked to work out the constructive programme of Khadi and National Education and purposely avoided publicity, till he was thrust into the

limelight by being selected by Mahatma Gandhi as the first individual Satyagrahi in 1940, before the famous 'Quit India' movement. So the modest Vinoba, one fine day woke to find himself famous. In fact, he is the embodiment of the famous eleven tenets of the Mahatma, enumerated in the following Marathi verse—

अहिंसा सत्य अस्तेय ब्रह्मचर्य असंग्रह ।

शरीरश्रम अस्वाद सर्वत्र भयवर्जन ।

सर्वधर्मो समानत्व स्वदेशी स्पर्श-भावना ।

हीं एकादश सेवावीं नम्रत्व व्रत-निश्चयें ॥

He is a Jnani, Karmayogi and Bhakta, all three rolled into a magnificent specimen of humanity.

He is a true Jnani or man of wisdom, of the type of Shankaracharya and a true Bhakta of the calibre of Ramkrishna Paramahansa of Bengal or Ramana Maharshi of Madras. Like these two saints, he goes into 'Samadhi' and finds himself in tune with the Infinite. Once, on the verge of being washed away and drowned by the strong current of a river to which he had gone for a dip, face to face with death, he was found loudly shouting, "I am not the body, I am the spirit which the river can never destroy." He actually experiences what the Gita says 'that our bodies are but so many clothes in which the eternal Atman is clothed and which he can discard at will like a man discarding his old worn-out garments'. His philosophy is that all mankind, nay the whole of Creation, is but a manifestation of the Brahman or Universal Soul and once people realise this, their essential nature, they will not foolishly fight and compete with each other. They will then act on the principle of Atmaupaniya—www.vinoba.in as I am so is the other, in fact, I and the

other are one, we are manifestations of the same spirit, sparks of the same 'fire divine,' in the words of the Upanishad. Then, they will really appreciate the fundamental goodness of their own nature and act upon it.

What Kabir says—'the whole earth belongs to the Lord of the Universe' "सबै भूमि गोपाल की" (Sabai Bhoomi Gopal Ki)—is quite true, because we are all manifestations of the same spirit. Sabai Bhoomi Gopal ki because Sabai Avatar Gopal ke. Once they understand this, they will readily accept the truth of the formula—"To each according to his necessity and from each according to his capacity". Then they will willingly agree to the division of land, according to the needs of the whole society and of no particular class or individual, as such. Vinoba is as great a Karmayogi or man of action as Lokmanya Tilak or Mahatma Gandhi. To him knowing is doing. As soon as he is convinced of the truth of a particular proposition, he will put his whole heart and soul into the doing of it. Hence as soon as the truth of the proposition that 'land must be given to the landless', dawned on him at Pochampalli in Telangana, he had no time to spare, in carrying it out with all its implications. Every minute of his life is devoted to action. The action may and did take various forms, like doing all kinds of work at the Ashram, scavenging, cooking, spinning yarn, teaching students in basic education and preaching philosophic sermons. Till recently he was on a 'walking tour' पदयात्रा Padayatra through the Zamindari-ridden parts of India on his present mission of (भूदान-यज्ञ) Bhoodana-yajna—land-gifts sacrifices. Collection of gifts of land, from those who have got it, distributing it among the landless poor, on a purely voluntary basis, is briskly going on. Vinoba compares himself to Waman,

an incarnation of God in the form of a dwarfish young boy asking for land from King Bali the Indian 'demos'. He is not satisfied with donation of land, (भूदान) Bhoodana, but he wants donations of money, (सम्पत्तिदान) Sampattidan to rehabilitate the landless who are to be given land and last but not the least, he wants donations of personal labour, (श्रमदान) Shramadana. Along with (भूदान) Bhoodan we must have (सम्पत्तिदान) Sampattidana and (श्रमदान) Shramadana from those who can afford. Then only will this programme be complete. And mind you, all this is on a purely voluntary basis. He appeals to the people on the level of love and cooperation and there is absolutely no coercion. The appeal is both to the head and heart of the audience and goes straight home, coming as it does from a Saint who practises what he preaches. He has already collected by way of donations, about 40 lakhs of acres of land, and what is very interesting is the fact, that whole villages, following the noble lead of village Mangroth in Uttarpradesh, are vying with each other where land can be completely redistributed on the basis of the ideal of 'Sarvodaya' or 'prosperity to all and poverty to none'. The most important psychological result is that he is creating a new spirit of love and goodwill and appealing to all and sundry to realise the brotherhood of man and the fatherhood of God. Are not God and man in fact one ?

Vinoba is an optimist, and his optimism is based on actual experience. He thinks that he will succeed in bringing about an atmosphere of love and good-will and co-operation which will hasten the day when the whole soil of India can be redistributed, so that none, who volunteers to work with his hands and body, will be refused a quantum of land which he can cultivate and exploit to the best of his ability. That

and that alone will solve the land problem of India, according to him.

Vinoba is a man with original ideas and he experiments ceaselessly with them. I will cite but a few by way of example; his ideas of 'Kanchan-mukti' or freedom from the power of money and return to the barter system; and philosophic anarchy, or ideal state where there will be no need of any external coercive agency, like Government, because every body will govern himself and the power of the state or government will ultimately wither away for want of use; and 'Shramadan-Pedhi' or labour bank, where every able-bodied agriculturist will be given credit for work which he will do in his spare time, and in his turn, receive money or work of his fellow villagers, when he wants it, after careful consideration and trial.

So our prayer on this auspicious occasion should go to the Lord of the Universe, that this great Messiah of devotion and action be spared to us for the full span of a hundred years, serving India till the last moment. In the words of the Upanishad, 'Jeeveta Sharadas Shatam' जीवेत शरदः शतम्, —May he live for a full century.

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Besides St. Vinoba my thanks are due to Shri Siddhraj Dhadda and Kaka Saheb Gadgil, Vice Chancellor Poona University, for helping me in my work. Thanks are also due to Shri Rajabhan Mangalwedhekar, Yadunath Thatte, V. V. Bhagwat of Chalisgaon and other friends. Mention must be made of Kumaries Kusum and Nirmala Deshpande and also of Shantidas Bhai for the material of my book-let. www.vinoba.in

—Author

ONE

THE SOUL IS IMMORTAL

It is said of Panini, the ancient grammarian that even while he was being torn limb from limb and eaten by a tiger, he continued repeating - Shivoham, Shivoham - "I am the Lord", "I am the Lord". Some may think that this is a mere flight of imagination, or idle fancy. "It is distance", they say, "that lends enchantment to the view". But the following incident in the life of Vinoba, authenticated by Pundalik Kathagade, bears out the truth of one such story.

While staying at the Sabarmati Ashram with Gandhiji, one day Vinoba was taking bath in the river. As ill-luck would have it, the sand under his feet was washed away, with the result, that he lost his balance and fell into the current. He was rapidly going down the river. Now, any body in such a plight would cry for help. That is most natural. But believe it or not, instead of crying "save me", Vinoba shouted "Give my salutes to Bapu and tell him that Vinoba is washed away. But his soul is immortal." In the very jaws of death, he was experiencing immortality of the soul !

The onlookers raised an outcry and ran down the banks of the river parallel to Vinoba, but they were helpless. Luckily for the Bhoodan movement, which he was destined to conduct many years later, and for the Indian nation, there was a rock in the bed of the river, which Vinoba could catch hold of. He climbed the rock and when people reached

him, was found to be muttering to himself "The Soul is immortal, the Soul is immortal !"

TWO

HOW CAME THE INSPIRATION ?

Genius (as Success) is ninety-nine percent perspiration and one per cent inspiration. 'The wind bloweth where it listeth,' says the Bible. The origin of great movement is formed in a spark of divine inspiration. The idea of Bhoodan came like a flash of lightning to Saint Vinoba in one such inspired movement, illuminating his path.

It was the month of April, 1951. Vinoba was going on foot from the Sarvodaya conference at Shivrampalli to Telangana. The land problem in Telangana had assumed an ugly aspect. What with its murders, what with its fights and fires—the common people were sullen and terribly frightened. It was a heyday for the terrorists.

One day Vinoba was camping at Pochampalli, a village in Telangana. After the day's programme there was the usual prayer meeting. The meeting was attended by some influential men from the village, men and women. (Vinoba referred in his speech to the land problem.)

One of the Harijans, who sat in a corner of the meeting, got up and said "We work on the land, with the sweat of

How came the inspiration ?

our brow, but we have no land.” Vinoba asked him how much land they required. They hurriedly consulted together and calculated that they required about eighty acres of land.

Now this demand was most natural. Really speaking like the Sun, the Moon, Air and Water, land belongs to none. The whole of mankind is like so many children of Mother Earth. Whoever is willing to till and work on land, should be entitled to have it. The idea of private property in land is a fad and it deserves an early burial. These were the favourite ideas of Vinoba and the question raised by the Harijan brother strongly appealed to him. He, in his turn, appealed to the conscience of the audience and asked them if there was none generous enough to satisfy this just and natural demand. There was pin-drop silence in the audience for some time. The demand was just and human though new and a little peculiar. But Vinoba's appeal to their humanity was not to go in vain and one gentleman stood up, as if in a flash of lightning and offered not eighty, but one hundred acres of his land for his untouchable brethren. His face lighted up, with a strange joy and satisfaction. The Ganga of Bhoodan, descended to the Earth like the Bhagirathi of old from heaven. An ecstasy of joy lighted the Saint's face and the people were simply electrified. Long live the first Bhoodan donor of Pochampalli—Shri Ramachandra Reddy !

●

Anecdotes of Vinoba

THREE

GOD IN EVERYTHING

Vinoba, the itinerant saint of India, wandering on foot from Village to Village in his great campaign of Bhoodan one day arrived at the village Vijaypur. The simple villagers were delighted and raised a beautiful platform. Plantains, oranges, papai and other fruits were there as offerings to the saint. A crowd of people from surrounding villages attended the meeting.

Vinoba made a stirring speech and appealed to the people to come forward, to make an offering of land and take away God's blessing. 'These fruits are waiting for you' he said. People rushed to the dais to obey the Saint. A hump-backed old woman came forward. Vinoba asked her 'Mother, have you any gift to make?' She replied, 'Oh, Yes. I shall make a gift out of the two bighas that I own. People are making gifts and taking back God's blessing in the form of fruit. I must not lag behind. Write down that I give away one bigha.' As she made this generous gift, Vinoba, gave her a fruit with his own hand. Tears of satisfaction rolled down from her eyes and there was not an eye that was not wet.

Vinoba made a reference to this 'Widow's mite', in the evening meeting and said 'I saw God in the form of that widow. The widow thought, that God in his grace, accepted her humble offer of land. But I found God's blessing on the Bhoodan movement, in that gift.'



The miracle of Mangroth

FOUR

THE MIRACLE OF MANGROTH

The movement of Bhoodan Yajna, began with the incident of Pochampalli, which has made the name of Ramchandra Reddi immortal. That incident can very well be the theme of a saga—an old story of the great doings of men. Pochampalli was the beginning and Mangroth, where the people voluntarily donated the whole village, was a natural fruition. Koraput district in Orissa marked the third big step where Gramdan—village donation—spread like wild fire, hundreds of villagers agreeing to redistribution of land on a voluntary basis, so that none in the area should be without land.

The Miracle of Mangroth, came about in the following way :

The Zamindar of Mangroth is Diwan Shatrughna Singh, a well-known leader in these parts. His better half who is affectionately called “Ranisaheb” is a tireless worker. She has visited practically every village in the district (Hamirpur), advising women to give up the purda and spin cotton on the Charkha. When Vinoba's party crossed the river Betwa, Nirmalabahan, a lady belonging to the party, asked a plain simple woman, who began to walk with the party, who she was. She replied that she was a ‘labourer’. They later came to know that it was the ‘Rani’ herself. It was due to her example that hundreds of ladies had taken part in the ‘Quit India’ movement, and courted jail.

So, the ground was already well prepared by this devoted couple and they cordially received and welcomed the message

Anecdotes of Vinoba

of Vinoba, that the whole land belonged to Gopal or God and that a village should act and work as one family. With this message of Vinoba in their hearts, they returned home from the banks of the Betwa, only two miles from Mangroth. They had decided that rather than compel Vinoba to walk two miles to Mangroth, in the heart of Bundelkhand, they would themselves meet him on his way.

So the simple villagers of Mangroth made history, by coming to the memorable revolutionary resolution, to pool their landed resources together, and redistribute them according to the needs of individual farmers.

The Diwan Sahab had been touring the country around, carrying the message of Bhoodan and returned home at 11 p. m. Neither lecture nor meeting nor any kind of propaganda was needed. The simple villagers simply announced their decision. The Diwan was whole-heartedly with them and donated the whole of his land, thus becoming an actual labourer along with the rest. The villagers were simply delighted and they were in high glee at their own action of self-sacrifice. One or two of them were remonstrated with by their wives, 'Now what will you eat?' 'The Diwan Sahab is an eccentric, but how can we afford to follow that rich man?' complained one villager's wife. Her husband who was in an ecstasy of joy at his own self-sacrifice replied, 'But I have two strong hands and I can work with them'. It was the Rani, however, who came to their help, in the nick of time. She went round every home, entreated the women folk not to place obstacles in the path of this peaceful revolution, but to be the torch bearers.

The miracle of Mangroth

Now, while the blood of thousands was spilled like water in Russia, to bring about this result and unspeakably cruel methods were followed, the same has been accomplished by the simple peasant in India who is said to have medieval outlook, almost overnight. He is hardly aware even of the great revolution that he has brought about with this simple looking decision of his.

Mangroth has one hundred and eleven families. Sixtysix of them possessed land and the rest were landless. Now, the land belonged to the whole village and they got it back from the Lord as his blessing. So now there is no problem of landless labour in Mangroth. All work with their hands and enjoy the use and fruit of land. The children of the village will be educated in the common village school together and choose their occupations according to inclination and merit. The women have discarded the purda and work along with men on equal terms. If somebody is ill, the whole village will take care of him. If somebody is in difficulty, the whole village will run to his help and wipe his tears.

But this simply is the beginning. The people of Mangroth, like the people of other Gramdan villages with the blessing of the saint, are treading an altogether new path leading to a new world. The ideal is, like the horizon, ever receding as they advance further. But this march towards the goal fructifies the great aim of human endeavour. The ambition of the rural population of Mangroth to cut away the distance and difference between the ideal and the real, may appear in the words of Shakespeare as 'vaulting ambition'. But the higher

Anecdotes of Vinoba

one flies in the sky, the nearer he goes to the feet of the Lord. Time runs fast and man has to make a choice between Co-prosperity and total destruction.

‘The people of Mangroth are common-folk like other villagers. Then why cannot every village in India follow the shining example of Mangroth ?’—Vinoba now-a-days puts this question to people wherever he goes. ‘Why should not a thousand lamps be lighted with the light of one ?’

●

FIVE

THE STORY OF MANPUR

What Mangroth is to Uttar Pradesh, Manpur is to Utkal—the first Gramdan Village. Baba* personally went to have a ‘darshan’ of the village folk of Manpur. Manpur thus had the unique honour of being the first gramdan village to be visited by Vinoba.

A thick mist covered the whole neighbourhood like a blanket. And the bed of the river Vaitarani had broadened very considerably, owing to the vicinity of the sea. So it was not possible to know the direction in which the boat carrying Vinoba and his party was moving. The neighbour-

* Vinobha is addressed as Bāba by his followers and admirers.

The story of Manpur

hood resounded with the 'Jais' of Bhoodan and its author. So we guessed that Manpur was now nearby. The village folk of Manpur were dancing with joy to the sounds of Tal and Mridanga. Their joy knew no bounds. Their eyes glistened with a new spirit, which was inspiring them. Their enthusiasm was contagious. The whole village was clean like a mirror, and bore testimony to the pure hearts of the villagers. Vinoba heartily blessed those rural heroes, complimenting them on doing a great deed. They were running here and there, for the whole time as if inspired, looking to the comforts of the guests. The Chief Minister of Utkal, had specially come there, to pat them on the back. Today's simple meal tasted like a delicacy, partaking of the sweetness of their hearts happy at the thought of having done their duty.

The Gramdan had come about in this way. Some workers went to Manpur, with the message of Vinoba, which ran thus—"The earth is our mother and we are her sons. It is improper to call ourselves 'owners' of land. God is the real owner. Turn your village into one family and be a big brotherhood." The villagers thought hard and long. They appreciated the spirit of Vinoba's message, but found that there were some practical difficulties, in its fulfilment. But the seed was well sown and Bhoodan workers were there to water it. So the plant grew up and the people took the decision to donate the whole village in Gramdan. The news spread throughout Utkal like wild fire. Manpur got publicity, in the newspapers and in the pleader's Chamber. So, on the full moon day of Vaisakh, the lands at Manpur were redistributed. Now nobody owned any land in Manpur. The whole land belonged

Anecdotes of Vinoba

to God. The land was redistributed for cultivation in proportion to the size of each family. A 'Sarvodaya Mandal' was established. It manages the affairs of the whole village. The message of the Charkha had already reached the village.

In the afternoon, all the villagers in a body, came to see Vinoba. They now saw face to face, the Saint in whose name they had effected the silent revolution and felt very much gratified. He advised them to realise that outward things like name and form were mere illusion and only God was the reality.

They talked with Vinoba in full loving confidence freely exchanging their thoughts. They told him that they held the meetings of 'Sarvodaya Mandal' twice every month, i. e. every full moon and every new moon day. Vinoba humorously asked them, whether the darkness of the new moon night affected their brains. Shivacharan, the Loyal 'sevak' of the village, replied, "In the eyes of the ordinary people, there was moon-light on full moon night and darkness on the new moon night. But they walked in the light of the Lord and therefore had full light even on the new moon night." Vinoba was highly pleased with the reply. He said "All the days are equally good, but these two days are specially so. When the devotee separates himself from God and works in this world, he gets the light, as if from the moon and when he merges himself in God, he sees the splendour of the stars, as on the new moon night." Vinoba asked whether they had any grievance or difficulty. Shiva-charan replied, "The grievance has disappeared. The Bhoodan Samiti has given us help. We are aware that the name of

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The Boy Donor

Manpur has become well-known throughout India and are conscious of our responsibility. Now, wherever we go, we shall propagate this idea. Sometimes, however, doubts arise in our mind that somebody might give us evil thoughts and change our attitude. But then we think of you and that thought gives us strength." Then under the expanse of the open sky, with the Sun as their witness, they prayed fervently to the Almighty. Vinoba at the end expressed the hope, that his dream of an ideally developed village would come true at Manpur. ●

SIX

THE BOY DONOR

In his Bhoodan campaign, Vinoba one day arrived at a small village and camped as usual for the day. In the evening, there was the usual prayer meeting. Vinoba in his suave words appealed to the villagers for donation for the landless. But today somehow or other, none would come forward even after repeated appeals. The river of mercy, could not break through the barriers of stony hearts, it seemed. Vinoba once more appealed in the name of 'Daridra Narayana'. For two or three minutes there was a dead silence. On the tip-toe of expectation, a young boy hardly in his teens stood up.

Anecdotes of Vinoba

Determination was writ large on every muscle of his boyish face. The Ganga of generosity flowed freely now from his heart. He said 'I offer my land consisting of ten acres.' The audience looked at him with admiration. Some thought that this child's offer was thoughtless. Others were simply stunned at this reckless generosity. But the idea of Bhoodan is Nature's message more easily appreciated by the villagers and the children than by sophisticated town and city dwellers. Its appeal to their innocent, straight-forward, selfless hearts, is direct as from soul to soul.

Vinoba himself was all admiration, but he could not accept this minor's gift. He asked the boy, 'Where is your father, child ?' But his father was dead. At the end of the meeting, however, the boy's widowed mother came there and requested Vinoba to accept the gift. ●

SEVEN

THE ORIGIN OF 'GITAI'

The literati from Bengal had come to Balarampur and, at the beginning of the evening prayer meeting, were introduced to Baba. He told these Bengali men of letters the origin of his Marathi translation of Gita which is called Gitai. The Gita is to many devout Hindus what the Bible is to the Christians. "I was fond of writing verses

The origin of 'Gitai'

as a boy," Vinoba began. "Whenever I completed a verse and was satisfied with it, I threw the writing into the fire. Once my mother told me to bring her a translation of the Gita in Marathi. I bought one but she did not like it because it was rather difficult to understand. "Vinya," said she, "Why do you not translate the book yourself?" She was confident that her son is quite capable of translating the Gita into Marathi.

At this stage, Vinoba stopped for some time, his throat being choked with emotion. His tender heart was full of the sacred, sweet and loving memory of his mother. He continued with difficulty, "If I owe my present power to any body it is my....." and could not complete the last word of the sentence. Tears ran down his eyes, and the learned men of Bengal too wiped their eyes. The whole meeting sat still like a picture. Vinoba continued after a while, "My mother was the source of strength. She had unlimited confidence in my capacity; that living faith of hers gave me immense strength. 'Gitai' which I wrote in my later life, though my mother unluckily did not live to see or hear it, was the fruit of this mother's love. A litterateur derives his power direct from God. I want God's blessings for my programme through your lips." Flowers in the form of sacred tears, sweet words and sentiments, gave out fragrance which wafted on the wind and the literati returned home spell-bound ! ●

VINOBA IN THE LAND OF BUDDHA

When he entered Bihar, the land of Lord Buddha, Vinoba announced, as if at his inspiration, that he would not leave it without solving the land problem of Bihar.

"I am following in the footsteps of Lord Buddha. Compared with the Lord I am a mere pigmy. But I am, figuratively speaking, sitting on his shoulders. So the result that could not be achieved then can be accomplished in these times." The story of Shrāvasti told by Vinoba in this connection is most wonderful. Once the people of Shrāvasti invited Lord Buddha for recuperation and rest for the four months of the rainy season; they wanted a small piece of land to erect a hut for the Lord's residence. So his devotees approached the big land owners for the donation of a piece of land. The land owners refused to give any land free. They would agree to sell, as much land for a gold mohur, as would be covered by it when placed on the ground. And the devotees of Buddha had no choice, but to buy land at this fancy price. Vinoba continued, "The land owners sold even the small piece of land required for Lord Buddha's cottage at an exorbitant price and in that very town of Shrāvasti, an ordinary person like me, a few months ago, got a gift of no less than a hundred acres. So, tell me whether this is Kaliyuga or Satyayuga. If you ask me, whether in the present Kaliyuga my philosophy will hold water, my reply is that there is no hard and fast demarcation of one yuga from another. Ravana and Kansa existed in the Yuga of Ram

Be truly royal in spirit

and Krishna and Gandhiji was born in our (so-called) Kaliyuga. We create our own Yuga or age. Just as a planet has its own atmosphere, so every individual creates his own surrounding atmosphere, because we are all of us sparks of the divine fire.”

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NINE

BE TRULY ROYAL IN SPIRIT

In the Sultanpur district of Uttar Pradesh, there is a Jaghir called ‘Amethi’. The Zamindar is called ‘Rana’ or King. The name of the present Rana is Rana Jayasinha. His ancestors have been ruling over this estate for centuries. Formerly, there were three hundred and twentysix villages in all within this estate. But a trust for public purposes has been effected for twentysix villages and now only three hundred villages remain in his Kingdom. Sultanpur district, as a whole, contains twenty five hundred villages in all.

Vinoba told the Rana, that he did not want him to be the owner of three hundred villages only, but he wanted him to be a true king of all twenty-five hundred.

The Rana is an educated gentleman learned in the Sanskrit language and the Vedas. He is free from all kinds of

addictions. He does not drink nor even does he chew betel leaf. He has the heart of a true sentimental devotee.

Vinoba further advised him to donate land to the greatest extent and himself take up the begging bowl. As a member of the Royal family, he must show Royal traits of character : generosity and princely nobility. He must not be sorry that his patrimony was slipping away from his hands. When a son comes of age, does not the father hand over the management of the estate to him ? So a democratic prince should treat his subjects like his sons, and try to become a true servant of the people. The motto of the Prince of Wales is 'Ich dien', —I serve. Then only will his people find a niche for him in their loving hearts. Due to the movement of Bhoodan Yajna, no one will be poor. Rich and poor all alike will earn their bread with the sweat of their brow. The Rana took the lesson of this advice to his heart and donated hundreds of acres of his land, for Bhoodan.

TEN

A TRUE HARIJAN OR SERVANT OF GOD

We all know that 'Harijan' is a new coin introduced by Mahatma Gandhi. The word as such was there, but formerly it meant a devotee of God. Now it has come to

A true Harijan or servant of God

mean, one who belongs to the so-called 'untouchable' class which is luckily no longer untouchable either in the eye of law or in the enlightened educated society. Among the untouchables, there were and are gems like Raidas Chamar or late Dr. Ambedkar the famous leader of the Mahārs.

The following is the story of one such rare gem among the poor lowly Harijans of North India. Vinoba was once touring Uttar Pradesh, in his Bhoodan Campaign. The Pada-Yatra or foot march, begins in the small hours of the morning. The luggage of the members of Vinoba's party is carried to the next halting place in a bullock cart, a villager from the last halt acting as a guide to the next.

So the baggage of the Yatris or members of the touring party of Vinoba, was being carried in a cart from Gorakhpur. A poor Harijan was acting as a guide. It was dark outside, but inside the heart of this man, a new light had been lit since he heard Vinoba's holy message in the evening meeting at Gorakhpur. At the end of the meeting, gift deeds had literally been showered on the Saint, and that set our Harijan friend to doing some hard thinking. The call for sacrifice, touched a ready and sympathetic chord in his heart. He thought of making a gift, but how and how much, was the question. He had only five acres of land with which to feed twelve souls. He could neither solve this riddle nor sit with folded hands, while the holy Ganga of Bhoodan was flowing past. At last he opened his heart to a member of Vinoba's entourage. He asked him whether he (the Harijan) could do something under the circumstances. The member was touched. The Harijan placed his difficulty

before him thus. "We are twelve people in the family," he said, "and there are only five acres of land to support us. Some of us have to add to the family income by working as labourers. The urge to give is there, but how and how much, is the question. Will you please point a way out of this difficulty?"

The Yatri had no ready made reply to this dilemma. He was all humility before the manifestation of this generosity. For the satisfaction of the soul's craving of this poor Harijan brother, Vinoba accepted the gift of a few gunthas* from his five acres.

And one golden deed inspires another. That is so very true. The driver of the bullock cart in the afternoon, while eating his bread along with the Harijan guide, heard the story of the Harijan's Bhoodan from his own lips. He enthusiastically offered a portion from his small holding. He was in a fix like the Harijan. But now his problem existed no longer. In the evening meeting after prayers, the cartman placed his gift deed at the feet of Vinoba.

* part of an acre

ELEVEN

THE SOLITARY CHAMAR DONOR OF BADAGAON

Badagaon literally means a large or large-hearted village, but Saint Vinoba found it to be neither. This came to light, in the evening prayer meeting at Badagaon. Of

The solitary chamar donor of Baḍagaon

course, there was the usual crowd of the rustics of that village and surrounding ones. That was all right.

After the prayer Vinoba made his appeal for land gifts. And several people responded to the appeal. But strange to say, the donors all were from surrounding villages. In a sense, the meeting was quite successful. But Baḍagaon people stood like a rock, with their stony hearts untouched by sympathy. Vinoba remarked, "I have spent the whole day in this village, the people from the neighbourhood have responded quite well. But Baḍagaon has remained high and dry. Are you going to send me away empty-handed? Alright! What you have not done today, you will do tomorrow. That is my hope."

The people of Baḍagaon returned from the meeting. But there was one exception. One Chamar (Shoe-maker) came panting to the meeting place. His face showed great sorrow. He did not like that the great Saint should carry such a bad impression about his village. He was in great grief. And he saved the name of Baḍagaon from utter shame and ignominy. He had saved a small sum with the sweat of his brow and only lately bought a piece of land. He donated that land to the Rishi, in full. "I have not sent away Vinoba empty handed," he said. That gift was much appreciated by Vinoba. ●

THE SHINING EXAMPLE OF TIKARDI

It is simply physically impossible for Vinoba to visit each and every village in India, their number being roughly seven lakhs. But greatly as they desired the personal presence of the Saint, the people of the small village Tikardi were appreciative enough to understand the impersonal message of Bhoodan. The whole atmosphere was electrified and how could Tikardi resist the appeal? Vinoba's workers had already reached the village.

The people of the village gathered before the 'Chavdi' (a place of meeting) and decided to carry out Vinoba's behest. They took a census of the number of houses in the village, which were thirty two. They also found that twelve householders had no land. Then they calculated, how much land these twelve would need. They unanimously fixed the number of acres needed.

Twenty landowners made up the required quota, and then they respectfully gave each of the landless his full quota. Tikardi had no more problem of providing for the landless labour.

Then all the villagers came to Vinoba's camp in a procession, shouting Bhoodan slogans and 'Victory to Saint Vinoba'. Vinoba had no need to give them a lecture, as they had already fulfilled his heart's desire. He only gave his cordial blessings and wished them the best of luck. And now co-operation is the 'mantra' of Tikardi. All of them, without an exception, till the land with the sweat of their brow and enjoy the fruits thereof. ●

Kanpur Ranks First

THIRTEEN

KANPUR RANKS FIRST

It was the last day of Vinoba's camp in the Kanpur district. Kanpur ranked first in many respects in the Bhoodan campaign; so actual distribution of land, at the hands of Vinoba was scheduled to take place in this very district. Vinoba himself visited the village of Pukhrayan and the neighbouring village of Sunaripur, and carefully inspected the land which he had obtained in donation. The land was under cultivation and of a high fertility. In between two pieces of land, there was a third piece which was not donated. But when Vinoba inquired about it, the owner donated the same willingly; the fact of the actual giving over possession of donated lands was made public by the workers, with a beat of drum. "Today land will be distributed by Vinoba to the landless poor at 10 O'Clock," so ran the announcement. And the villagers were requested to witness the ceremony. They could not at first believe their ears. In the presence of the whole village, there was an open inquiry about the names of landless persons. There were eight such persons in Pukhrayan and four in Sunaripur. They were then working as casual labourers on the lands of others.

The meeting which in the words of Vinoba was "a most pleasant occasion", began in a cordial atmosphere. The dais was suitably decorated with festoons of mango leaves, and there were the auspicious figures drawn in colours.

Then it was explained, that the proposed donee must be without any land, without any other profession or means

Anecdotes of Vinoba

of livelihood, and willing and able to cultivate the piece of land given. There were twelve such people and there was land available for only six of them, at the rate of five acres per family. So the landless persons were themselves asked, to choose six from among themselves. They were to choose the poorest six. Vinoba was to distribute the land, in the presence of the villagers, who were to witness the ceremony. About one third of the land to be distributed, was to go to Harijans.

The landless persons were dumb-founded at the idea of owning land without any terms or conditions. So Vinoba got down from the platform and began lovingly to stroke them on their backs, and have a heart to heart chat with them. One Harijan brother, moved with emotion said with a lump in his throat, "I have grown-up sons and we can earn our bread with our hands." "But," he pointed to another and said "his children are still young. So he is poorer than I. Give him land first." The eyes of all who witnessed the scene were filled with tears and they had to wipe them. Competition is the watchword today and "everybody for himself and the devil take the hindmost" appears to be the favourite slogan. And this poor Indian Harijan rustic says "My neighbour's need is greater than mine, so give him the land first." Has Kritayuga begun on this earth again? But this lowly pioneer of the new creation was pointing the way. He wore rags on his body, but his heart was of pristine gold. Compassion, generosity, pity all these noble sentiments were fully roused in his heart. He was a true descendant of the sage Dadhichi, who gave his bones to prepare arms for the destruction of the demons.

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Vinoba appealed to the audience to come forward and donate the land required to make up the deficit. "I donate five acres" was the ready response from one member of the audience. "So are we to send away the rest without land?" Two more persons responded this time. "Such an occasion may never come again in your lives," remarked Vinoba. The poor patwari (revenue representative of the Government) was witnessing this whole moving scene. He came forward with an offer of two bighas and a quarter. One displaced person from Pakistan who had begun life anew in India, and was a prosperous merchant had purchased twelve bighas of land. He had already donated five bighas but he could not resist the appeal. He donated the whole of his land. And then to crown it, one man stood up and offered to make up the remainder. Thus all the landless persons could have land from then onwards. So now there was no question left of making an invidious choice, among the landless. The Harijan who set the ball rolling saying "My brother's need is greater than mine" gave the inspiration to the other donors. He had given a new slogan to the whole world—"Not I, but my brother."

Vinoba then spoke with a voice husky with emotion. He could not resist shedding tears of joy. "India's heart is now seen in its nobility. And still doubting Thomases continue asking me whether I hoped to get the necessary quantity of land for the asking. But you have today seen with your own eyes what this holy land watered by the sacred Ganga and Yamuna is capable of achieving." ●

Anecdotes of Vinoba

FOURTEEN

THE TWO BROTHERS QUARREL

A quarrel among brothers for loaves and fishes is not an uncommon happening. Land, houses, money, all these are root causes of such quarrels and not unoften. Litigation, fights, and even murders are the result. But a general love between brothers like that of Rama and Bharat, is not a mere figment of imagination. The following is the story of one such unusual quarrel among two brothers.

Vinoba was visiting the village in his Bhoodan tour and after the prayer, there was the usual meeting. The people filled in gift-deeds. One of the villagers was thinking of donating some land. But they were two brothers and the younger brother had gone out of the village on some errand and the land was their common property. What could he do without consulting his brother ? Both of them dearly loved each other, lived and worked with each other. Under these circumstances, what was the elder brother to do ? He anxiously waited for his brother's return, but he did not arrive till the evening. Then the elder brother calculated what his share in the land would come to, and donated a part of it to Vinoba; then he went home and slept a good man's sleep.

The younger brother returned at night and in the way came to know of his brother's land gift. So he became angry and asked his brother, why he differentiated between them thus. "You should have as well donated a portion of my share of land too !" He argued, "But how could I do it

Let Children Not be Idlers

without consulting you ?” asked his brother. The younger one retorted, “Have I ever differed from you on any point before ?” He was angry not because land was donated by his brother, but because his portion was not touched. Then he also donated from his portion to Vinoba.

●

FIFTEEN

LET CHILDREN NOT BE IDLERS

Vinoba was touring in the Sonagar district of Madhya Pradesh, carrying his message of Bhoodan from village to village. People even in small villages lovingly requested Vinoba to stop in their villages, and accept gifts for Bhoodan. And then the caravan of Bhoodan moved on.

Once people in one such small village stopped him on the way. He gratefully accepted the invitation. There was a small meeting. Vinoba in his effective way explained the idea of Bhoodan. The villagers had already filled in some gift deeds, which were presented to Vinoba. Meanwhile an old gentleman stood up and said, “I offer the whole of my six acres of land to Bhoodan. Please accept it.” Vinoba asked him how he proposed to maintain himself after giving away the whole of his land. “I labour with my hands and I had saved enough money to buy this land.” “How many

Anecdotes of Vinoba

children have you ?” “I have three.” Then would you not like to leave something for them ? “No, No, I do not want my children to be idlers. Let them learn to stand on their own legs. I have given serious thought to this question. And I believe that this would conduce to the welfare of my children.”

All the people were astonished at this remarkable donation.

SIXTEEN

SAKSHI GOPAL OR GOD IS MY WITNESS

Pilgrims who visit the temples of Jagannath at Puri do not return without visiting the temple of Sakshi Gopal. It is an old legend. People from far and wide, come to visit the temple at Gokul-Vrindavan. One old Brahmin from Kanchipuram in the South, had gone there for ‘darshan’ of the deity. He fell critically ill. A young fellow pilgrim nursed him back to health. The old man was highly pleased and to show his gratitude promised the young man his daughter’s hand in marriage. But after returning home, he changed his mind. The young man expostulated with him after entreating him, but to no purpose. At last he asked the ‘Panchas’ of his village to give him justice. The Panchas

Sakshi Gopal or God is My Witness

asked him about his witness. The young man replied that God Gopal of Vrindavan was his sole witness. The Panchas asked the young man to produce the witness in Court. The youth went to Vrindavan and fervently prayed to God to come as his witness. He would not leave the temple of God. He sat Dharana for three days and nights. At last on the third day he heard a deep sound. "I shall come with you, as your witness. You please start for home tomorrow morning. I shall follow you." The youth asked, "But suppose you do not come after all. How am I to know that you will come for certain?" The voice replied "I shall follow you with jingling silver rings in my feet. But you should never look back. Or, I shall stop there and then." The youth was delighted. He got up in the morning and started on his return journey. He heard the sound of jingling silver all right. So he proceeded further. Then he came to a sandy desert where the sound could no longer be heard. So he looked back, to make sure that God was following him. As a matter of fact, the sands of the desert were responsible, for the mischief of inaudibility. But God Gopal, all the same, turned into a stone idol. The youth went back and prayed to God again. He wept in the agony of his soul, but all in vain. So he went back to Kanchipur and reported to the Panchas what had happened. They accompanied the youth to the desert out of curiosity. On seeing the stone image they believed the young man. The old Brahmin also relented and gave him his daughter. A temple was built round the idol. And that is how the Sakshi Gopal temple came into existence. ●

THE TRAGIC INCIDENT OF VAIDYANATH DHAM

This is an account of what happened to Vinoba and his party at the Vaidyanath Dham temple, notorious for its orthodox Hindu priests in Bihar. Vinoba does not as a rule visit temples where Harijans are refused entry. He is of the opinion that the idol in a temple from which Harijans are debarred becomes deprived of its life and vitality. But on the particular day of this incident the Chief Panda (i. e. Hindu priest) had sent an invitation to Vinoba in which it was asserted that Harijans were allowed in the temple, and that he was cordially invited to come. So Vinoba started in the solemn hour of the evening, for the darshan of Mahadeo, chanting the Mahadeo Suktas in his mind, with a party of Harijans. In the compound outside the temple, masses of people had gathered to witness the unique visit. Vinoba reached the chief gate of the temple. The usual slogans and shouts of victory to religion and death to Adharma were raised. Vinoba entered the compound. Along with the shouts of "Dharma Ki Jaya Ho" came the opposite shouts of "Don't enter the temple". And then the real meaning of the shouts "Dharma Ki Jaya Ho" became evident. There was then a great commotion. In the dim light of kerosene lanterns, nothing was clearly visible. Vinoba climbed up a mound and tried to pacify the people. He said, he would not go inside the temple. But in the pandemonium that followed, his voice could not be heard. The 'sevaks' stood in a circle round Vinoba. Then blows and lathis began to

Lanza Del Vasta Shantidasbhai

have full play. The sevak volunteers of Vinoba bravely receiving the blows, brought him safely out of the precincts of the temple. And then everything became quiet after a time. Ramdeo Babu remarked that history was reversed today somehow, and the demon Bakasur was beating Bheema today. The sevaks remarked that the wonder of it was, that they had no ill feeling absolutely for the Pandas who were responsible for the mischief. Two or three members of Vinoba's party were seriously hurt. But Vinoba escaped with a severe blow on his right ear. "That was the 'Prasada' of Vaidyanatha," he said.

EIGHTEEN

LANZA DEL VASTA "SHANTIDASBHAI"

Shantidasbhai was the name given to M. Lanza Del Vasta, when he came to India many years ago to pay a visit to Gandhiji. He is an Italian who has adopted France as his field of activity. He was with Vinoba's march for Bhoodan, for three months in Bihar. His serious face, calm and serene, his long white beard matching his white skin and the cross in his neck gave him the appearance of a Saint. He is a musician and artist of no mean order. In the morning, at the prayer meeting he sang his Latin Song to the accompani-

Anecdotes of Vinoba

ment of a guitar. The audience then actually perceived the truth of the line "nearer my God, to Thee". Vinoba highly appreciated the performance.

Shantidasbhai's one pet programme was to draw pencil sketches of Vinoba in different poses and postures. Vinoba addressing a meeting, stepping quickly and lightly, praying to God in a contemplative mood—these poses of Vinoba were very carefully noted by him, and then he would draw pencil sketches, with a light delicate hand. He was sometimes chidden (by Kumari Kusum Deshpande) that he was turning Vinoba into another Jesus Christ. The similarity of the faces was so remarkable. To this taunt Shantidasbhai would reply with a smile "But why do you say so ? Are you sure that Christ and Vinoba are not one ?"

Shantidasbhai, has written a book on Vinoba in French, (translated into English under the title of "Gandhi to Vinoba" and published by Rider and Co. Booksellers of London) Those who know French, like it very much and say that it combines the pen of an artist and the heart of a devotee. Then Kusumtai remarks that she was sorry for not knowing French. But somewhere in her heart she felt the thrill of the chords of the guitar and the pencil sketches of Vinoba appeared before her mind's eye. Through the sublime music of the tremor of the chords of the guitar, the face of Jesus Christ would appear not clear but indistinct. Through the delicately drawn pencil sketches, the sounds of Bhajan could be heard and the heart was indescribably thrilled with joyous emotion. ●

A NOBLE KIND OF COMPETITION

"Everybody for himself and the devil take the hindmost" is the motto of this world of competition. Competition they say, helps the development of an individual's personality. But Vinoba feels, that co-operation and not competition, should be our guiding principle. The following is an example of a noble type of competition.

Wherever Vinoba goes, he electrifies the atmosphere with the idea of Bhoodan. The old and the young are found discussing this one topic. The minds of people are filled to the brim with noble sentiments, respect, admiration, astonishment and holiness. The splendid halo round the face of Vinoba reminds us of sages of ancient times, like Vashista and Valmiki. Tall and thin, Vinoba walks fast emitting a feeling of sacred sacrifice.

A young man listening to Vinoba's inspired words, was visibly moved and offered some land from his share. The audience applauded him for his generosity. But elbowing his way out of the audience, an old man came forward and asked for a form of the gift-deed. He was the father of the previous young donor.

The workers tried to dissuade him saying, "Baba, your son has given land in donation just now. It is not necessary for you to donate any more." The old man retorted, "My son has donated land out of his share and that is meritorious. But how can I be a sharer in his merit ? Let me also be meritorious on my own account."

Anecdotes of Vinoba

He was allowed to donate from his share and both father and son went back home greatly satisfied. The whole village was full of praise for them both. ●

TWENTY

MOHAMMAD PATHAN OF GUMGAON

The Pathans are supposed to be cruel, heartless people. But all Pathans are not alike. Here is a true story of a Pathan with a heart of gold.

Vinoba started on foot from Wardha to go to Delhi. The message of Bhoodan was broadcast to all and sundry, far and wide every day. Everyday brought within the sweep of the movement, new villages, new faces, new experience.

The thoughtful section of the public was attracted by the logic of the appeal, but the hearts of the masses simply melted with sympathy. Vinoba's words had the magic attraction of a 'Mantra'.

Mohammad Pathan of Gumgaon was an old soldier in the army of Gandhiji and had undergone rigours of jail life several times during the fight for Indian freedom. He had studied the Quran under Vinoba while in jail. When he heard that Vinoba could not visit his dear Gumgaon,
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Mohammad Pathan of Gumgaon

because it was a little out of the way, he simply could not stand it. He came straight to Vinoba and pressed him to include Gumgaon in his itinerary. Vinoba replied that he would willingly include Gumgaon in his tour, but Mohammad would have to pay his 'fees'.

Mohammad understood Vinoba's humour and was quite willing, nay eager to pay his share, but how could he speak for the whole village ? He was in a fix. He replied in an humble tone, that he could not speak for the whole village, but he was himself willing to donate the whole of his land. Vinoba could not withstand this appeal and was all praise for his service and sacrifice. So Mohammad was a happy man indeed, when Vinoba promised to visit Gumgaon.

In the meeting at Gumgaon the Pathan told his brother villagers of his determination to give away the whole of his land, lock, stock and barrel. Gumgaon had never lagged behind in the fight for Indian Independence and he was sure that it would keep up its reputation in the Bhoodan movement also.

And then, for an hour and a half, gift deeds were simply showered on Vinoba. That was a sight for gods to see. The Pathan was carried shoulder high by his fellowmen and Vinoba was more than satisfied with the 'fees' ! ●

THE MODERN MONKEY ARMY

The Ramayan tells us how the hero of that great epic conquered the Rakshasas or demons with the help of the army of monkeys. An army of modern monkeys—village children—has often helped Vinoba in his Bhoodan movement. When he reaches a village the children gather round Vinoba in numbers. And then the talk begins. The little urchins are quick in grasping the idea of Bhoodan. That was the experience in the village of Chandibrahmapur. Baba (Vinoba's familiar name) asked the youngsters: "Do you know why I have come to your village?" One of them replied: "Yes, we do. You have come to ask for land." Baba asked: "What am I going to do with the land?" The boys in a chorus replied, "You are distributing land to the poor people, who have got no land of their own." Baba: "Do you like this work?" The children replied with one voice: "Yes, yes, we like it very much." Baba: "Then you please do one thing. Go home each one of you and tell your parents, that Baba has come to our village to ask for gifts of land for the poor. He must be given land. But remember one thing. Your parents may reply 'Dearies, we own the land for your sake.' Tell them that they need not worry about you, that you will work, all in one team together and eat and enjoy together."

At these words the children ran home. And the wonder of it is, that they all came to the evening meeting, with their parents and made them give donations of land. Vinoba in

his speech, referred to the story how God himself had to bend before Prahlad, and mother Yashoda had to bow down before the little Krishna. He added, "These children became our volunteers and carried our message to the elders and dared to ask for land gifts. This is not an ordinary incident. God was helping me through these kids." ●

TWENTY-TWO

LORD KRISHNA, MURALI AND GOKUL

Lord Krishna with his crown of peacock's feathers and his flute made of simple bamboo is the ideal of Vinoba. He wore the flowers growing on the banks of the Jamuna. One gentleman, who had visited Germany, was once talking to Vinoba about an incident which took place in Germany.

"We were all of us students from different nations and had gathered together at a musical concert. Youths from France, Germany, England, Japan and Russia were there. All of them played music on their particular national musical instruments. The French played on the violin. The English did likewise. I was asked to play Indian music, but I discreetly kept mum, because I did not know which was our national musical instrument," Vinoba told him that the flute of bamboo reed was India's national instrument. It was very easy to make a flute. Lord Krishna loved his

rural Gokul, with its plenty of milk and butter, which he liked very much. He did not use sugar, because it could not be manufactured locally. He dearly loved the cowherd children from Gokul and fattened them on milk and butter. He extinguished the flames of quarrels and bickerings among the people of Gokul. This Gokul of Krishna is the ideal of rural India and gave Indian villages a new status and dignity. He loved the Indian countryside, its flora and fauna, hills and rivers, its natural scenery. Even when he became the Lord of Dwarka, he would ever and anon return to Gokul and its cows, handle cowdung, sweep cowsheds, wear garlands of wild flowers, play on his flute, and play with the cowherd children. Gokul abounded in joy and happiness. Even Gods envied the happiness of the children of Gokul. What did they lack ? There was every thing in heaven, except the love and affection of the inhabitants of Gokul. Money and sensual pleasures were there in plenty, but no joy of pure love. So we should turn the present Indian villages into Gokul. Then the rich men from the cities will flock to the villages to get milk and bread from the villagers. Gokul connotes ideal simplicity of villagers living together in peace and amity. It is an independent, healthy, industrious, loving, simple and quite unsophisticated way of life. Sugarcane is being crushed, at several places, the Charkha is humming its sweet music, carders are busy with their work, the oil press is giving out its peculiar sound, the village cobbler is busy making shoes, water is being raised from wells by 'mots' or leather vessels and the cowherds are grazing their cattle and in

their spare moments playing on the flute—that is my idea and ideal of an Indian village. Let us turn a grave-yard into a beautiful orchard and garden. ●

TWENTY-THREE

A REPRESENTATIVE OF RURAL INDIA

The peculiar trait of the land gifts of the village Tikardih was that, not only were all the landless labourers provided with land, but seeds, bullocks, and implements of agriculture were also given to them. The beauty of it was that the village folk did this voluntarily, without requiring the personal presence of Saint Vinoba. Vinoba calls this kind of land-gift 'daughter's marriage with ornaments as dowry' (Salankrita Kanyadan). There was a special meeting held for the reception of those simple rural folk. They were brought to the place of the meeting to the accompaniment of music and tom-toms. Most of the donors were themselves poor. Their bodies were frail, emaciated and covered with tattered clothes. Their faces showed marks of untimely old age due to suffering and anxiety, but their eyes shone with joy and satisfaction. Among them there was an old speckled farmer. Now and then, he looked at the Saint with eyes full of devotion and shed tears of joy. And then

he would look elsewhere in a pensive mood. What on earth was he thinking of ? Like Wordsworth's 'Solitary Reaper', was he also singing silently about old unhappy far off things ? His boyhood was passed on the lap of mother earth, communing with wheat and gram plants, playing Indian cricket with his young chums and possibly stealing raw mangoes. In his youth and manhood, he may have cheated his brothers for a small strip of land, or he may have affectionately fondled his younger brother, as his own child. He must have experienced the joys and sorrows of a poor farmer's life. And now in his old age, he was answering the clarion call of the Saint, to offer his poor man's mite. Success and failure, the obverse and reverse of the coin of his life, he must be pondering over, experiencing joy and sorrow, in his heart of hearts. His whole life was lighted by the divine love of this land-donation, voluntarily made. ●

TWENTY-FOUR

WHO CAME TO SCOFF

"Those who came to scoff remained to pray," says the poet. That this is not mere poetic fancy, but a hard fact can be seen from the following incident.

Who Came To Scoff

Vinoba was on tour visiting villages in Bengal and Utkal and was camping at a small town named Aska. Communists and greedy landlords infested the place. In the morning Vinoba's Bhoodan literature was sold here like hot cakes. There was a meeting in the afternoon, attended by the elite of the town. A member of the local bar, who attended the meeting was very angry with Vinoba and straightway accused him of 'stealing' people's land. It seems that even educated people of this place had scanty acquaintance with Bhoodan Literature. They did not know even the A B C of Bhoodan. Vinoba taunted these people, saying that if even after four years of Bhoodan work they had not read any literature on the subject, he would take them to be no better than illiterate people.

In the prayer meeting, Vinoba painted a rosy picture of a self-governing self-sufficient village, based on the idea of Sarvodaya or co-prosperity. "There can be, under Sarvodaya, no clash of class interests. The interest of all individuals and classes can be equally well served. The path of truth and non-violence leads to the welfare of both the rich and the poor alike." That was the substance of Vinoba's speech.

After the meeting, Baba was returning to his camp, when one man elbowed his way out of the crowd and touched Vinoba's feet in humility. Vinoba asked what the matter was. It was the same pleader, who had accused Vinoba in the afternoon meeting of being a thief of people's property. Hanging his head down in shame and remorse, he frankly apologized to Vinoba. "I have committed a great mistake.

Will you not forgive me ?” entreated the pleader. Patting him on the back, and saluting him with a smile, Baba moved on. The on-lookers asked themselves in astonishment, whether it was the same person, who abused Vinoba in the afternoon meeting and fell at his feet a few hours later.

TWENTY-FIVE

A CLAIRVOYANT BLIND MAN

Blind men cannot see and, therefore, naturally they cannot enjoy the beauties of nature hidden in the dancing creepers, in the colour effects of clouds or in the beauty of flowers or in the splendour of the stars. But the beauty of a noble soul is even richer than all these outward forms and colours put together. Ramchandran, a blind man, had such a noble soul. Choudharpur is a hamlet in the Moradabad district of Uttar Pradesh. Vinoba stayed at this small village in a tent. The workers were busy with the preparation of meals.

In the evening, there was the usual meeting following the prayer. Vinoba spoke before the people who had come from the surrounding villages. The donors were a few and land gifts nominal. But Vinoba was not down-hearted

A Clairvoyant Blind Man

at all. He retired to bed at the usual early hour, and his co-workers followed suit. All was calm and quiet. The goddess of peace reigned supreme.

At the hour of midnight, a bullock cart broke the silence with the jingle of the bells in the necks of the bullocks. A blind man, named Ramchandran, arrived in his cart. His co-villagers had attended the evening meeting, but being blind he could not come with them. But, when his fellows returned to the village, bringing news of the saint and his powerful appeal, his blind eyes glistened with a strange light. He shed tears of joyous emotion. That a half-naked Fakir was marching on foot begging for land for the landless was too much for him. He asked his son to yoke the bullockcart and arrived at Vinoba's camp at midnight hour. The surrounding darkness could not hide the light in Ramchandran's heart. His blind eyes had the beauty of full-blown lotuses. One of the followers of Vinoba arranged the gift deed at that hour and Ramchandran's joy knew no bounds when he signed it. He was in ecstasy at being in tune with the Infinite. His face was thoughtful and he was chanting the name of Ram and thinking of eternity. Vinoba's touch turned him into pristine gold ! ●

ALL OUT FOR JAYAPRAKASHJI

We all know the name of Jayaprakash Narayan the great socialist leader, who, when he took part in active politics, was freely mentioned as successor to Pandit Jawaharlal, if his party won at the polls.

Vinoba's Bhoodan movement has attracted this great leader to its fold, so that he has actually dedicated his life to it and is working as a trusted lieutenant of the great Vinoba. This co-operation, nay, heart union of these two great men is as holy and beautiful as the confluence of the Ganga and the Yamuna rivers at Prayag.

The following touching incident took place during Jayaprakashji's Bhoodan tour in Bihar. Bihar is the land of the great Gautama Buddha. The people of Bihar have taken to the land gift movement, as naturally as ducks take to water. In one village, Jayaprakashji was holding his Bhoodan meeting. He delicately touched the devotional chord in the hearts of the rustic audience. Their hearts responded nobly, but somehow there were only 20 donors and about a hundred acres as land gifts. Jayaprakashji expressed dissatisfaction at the poor number of donors in the land of Bhoodan and made another appeal. This time people came forward in numbers and gifts rapidly swelled.

Babu Shrivdhar Sinha stood up and offered his six and a half bighas. Jayaprakashji announced his offer. One worker meanwhile whispered in his ears that the donor had only six and a half bighas, and had no other means of maintenance. He would have to starve !

All out for Jayaprakashji

Jayaprakashji therefore said that he respected the spirit of offer, but would accept only one bigha from the six and a half. But the generous donor insisted on the total gift. He said that he would go on a fast, if his gift was not fully accepted. He added that he would work anywhere with his two strong hands. "Let my land-less brother now enjoy the fruits of the earth that I so long enjoyed," he added.

Tears stood in the eyes of the people, and Jayaprakashji's voice was husky with emotion, as he said, "I salute you brother. You are a true descendant of 'Dadhichi' who gave the bones from his body when requested and 'Shibi' who parted with a pound of his flesh to feed a bird. Excuse me, your will shall be done." And Babu Shivdhar Sinha, went away after the meeting a poor but a happy man.



The Vinoba Mission is a religious and social movement in India, founded by Mahatma Gandhi. It is based on the principles of non-violence, truth, and love. The mission aims to promote the welfare of the poor and the oppressed, and to bring about a radical change in the social and economic structure of India. The mission has been active in various parts of India, and has achieved many successes in its work. It has established many schools, hospitals, and other institutions, and has helped to improve the lives of many people. The mission is still active today, and continues to work for the betterment of the Indian people.



The Author

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